How to mix the colour and its shades

For painting, the simplest way to get red is to take it from the tube. In an ordinary painter's set it is one of the primary colours, which is why it cannot be mixed from other colours. But different reds **do not start in the same place**. One leans towards orange, another towards pink and violet. The ratios are approximate and every brand behaves a little differently, so try them out on paper first.

What to prepare

Basic red
The centre of the family from which everything else unfolds.

Cooler crimson
Leans towards raspberry and violet.

Warmer scarlet
Leans towards orange, tomato and poppy red.

Purple, or magenta
A strong pinkish red that adds a cool, raspberry tinge.

Yellow
Pushes towards orange tones.

Ultramarine blue
Deepens the mix towards wine and violet.

Green
Its counterpart on the colour wheel; it mutes.

Earthy brown
Helps you look for brick and earthy reds.

White
Lightens and often shifts towards pink.

How can you recognise it without technical names?

A warmer scarlet can remind you of a tomato or a wild poppy. A cooler crimson comes close to raspberries or a pinkish red. Names on tubes differ between makers, so put **small samples** side by side and **add white** to part of them. The tint will then be easier to see.

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What the additions do



White

Lightens and often shifts towards pink. Add it a little at a time.





Yellow

Leads towards orange tones.





Blue

Can deepen the mix towards wine or violet.





Green

A suitable green mutes; a large amount can create a brownish mix.





Earthy brown

Helps you look for brick and earthy reds.





Black

Try it a little at a time; it can darken the mix and dirty it. For darkening, brown or a little dark blue often works better.



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Ten reds to try

One part is an equal amount of paint. The ratios are our **approximate** starting points for experiments. The samples on screen are not the measured result of a recipe. Mix small amounts first and let them dry.

Soft pink

4 parts white + gradually about 1 part red. A strong red may need much more white.

Salmon

3 parts white + 1 part warmer red + a trace of yellow. Yellow pushes it towards orange; add it carefully.

Coral

3 parts warmer red + 1 part white + a small dot of yellow. Compare it with salmon; less white means a more saturated impression.

Brick

3 parts red + a small amount of yellow and earthy brown. Add the brown by the tip of the brush so the mix does not lose its red character.

Terracotta

2 parts warmer red + 1 part white + a little earthy brown; yellow as needed. Look for the tone of fired clay, not one obligatory colour.

Raspberry

2 parts crimson red + 1 part magenta; a little white if you like. If you already have a cool red, you may need less magenta.

Wine

3 parts crimson + a trace of ultramarine and, if needed, a little brown. Blue can stain strongly; try it in a separate portion.

Burgundy

3 parts red + ultramarine and brown added by the tip of the brush. The names wine and burgundy overlap; go by the actual sample.

Muted pink

4 parts white + 1 part red + a very small trace of a suitable green. Green can quickly mute the mix to grey or brown.

Earthy red

2 parts red + 1 part earthy brown; white as needed. Every brown shifts the mix elsewhere; write down the name of the tube.

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